until recently in academic and political circles. We should return to the negotiating table and renew the arms-control process that began in the wake of the Cuban missile crisis. We can’t wait for another crisis of such proportions to bring leaders back to their senses, as the next crisis may prove much worse than the previous one.

At the height of the Cold War, public debate put arms control on the political agenda: governments alone would not have done so. Thus, as citizens, we must reeducate ourselves about the history of nuclear weapons and the dangers they present so that a new arms-control regime can be negotiated. Elected politicians eventually listen to their electorates. As participants in democratic politics, we must relearn the forgotten lessons of the past in order to make politicians act upon them. Looking back is an essential prerequisite for moving forward.